

Texas WIC Health and Human Services Commission

Effective April 1, 2026

Policy No. FD:12.1

Food Package Substitutions, Tailoring and Exchanges

Purpose

To allow for food package substitutions, tailoring, and exchanges.

Authority

CFR 246.10

Policy

Food item substitutions can be made to meet participants' medical needs, cultural eating patterns, or food preferences. Food packages can be tailored or exchanged to meet participants' needs. These changes must be made by a Certifying Authority (CA) or WIC Certification Specialist (WCS).

Definitions

Electronic Benefit Account (EBA) - the account where participant food benefits are being held for redemption.

Procedures

- I. Substitutions in Food Packages
 - A. Food item substitutions can be made in the milk, cereal, and fruit and vegetable food groups to better meet the participants' needs and preferences. Available substitutions may vary per category.
 - B. Milk Substitution Group
 1. Substitutions can be made within children's and women's food packages, per participant's preference, for different types of milk (e.g., milk and evaporated milk) based on quart equivalents.
 2. Milk substitutions include:
 - a. Milk, lactose-free milk, and soy milk – one quart is

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- one quart equivalent
 - b. Pea protein milk – two 48-ounce containers is three quarts equivalent
 - c. Dry milk – 3.2 ounces is one quart equivalent
 - d. Evaporated milk – 16 fluid ounces is one quart equivalent (1:2 ratio)
 - e. Cheese – one pound is three quarts equivalent
 - f. Tofu – One pound (16 ounces) is one quart equivalent
 - g. Yogurt – one quart (32 ounces) is one quart equivalent
- 3. Cheese - Food packages cannot contain more than one pound of cheese with the exception of: Fully Breastfeeding, Fully Breastfeeding and Pregnant, Partially Breastfeeding and Pregnant, Pregnant with Multiples, Fully Breastfeeding Multiples, and Partially Breastfeeding Multiples food packages, which can contain a maximum of 2 pounds of cheese.
- 4. Yogurt
 - a. Food packages cannot contain more than two quarts of yogurt.
 - b. One pound (16 ounces) of tofu can be substituted for one quart of yogurt.
- 5. Tofu – Tofu can be issued up to the full fluid milk equivalence for reasons such as milk allergy, lactose intolerance and vegan diets.
- 6. Kosher milk and cheese are available for participants who must consume kosher foods due to religious eating patterns. Documentation is not required. Kosher milk and cheese can be issued by substitution in place of milk and cheese in the standard food package. Another option for participants who need to keep kosher is soy milk and tofu as soy milk is pareve (can be eaten with both meat and dairy dishes).

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- C. Cereal Substitution Group – Infant cereal can be substituted for breakfast cereal in women’s and children’s Special Dietary Needs food packages only. To receive this food package, staff must obtain a Texas WIC Medical Request form from the client’s Health Care Provider.
- D. Fruit and Vegetable Substitution Group –
 - 1. One juice item (64-ounce bottle or 16-ounce frozen juice) can be substituted for some of the fruit and vegetable cash value benefit (CVB) per participant’s preference.
 - 2. In women’s and children’s Special Dietary Needs food packages, jarred infant food fruits and/or vegetables can be substituted for fruit and vegetable cash value benefit (CVB). To receive this food package, staff must obtain a Texas WIC Medical Request form from the client’s Health Care Provider.

II. Tailoring Food Packages

- A. Individual nutrition tailoring is allowed based on the CA or WCS’ assessment of a participant’s supplemental nutrition needs.
- B. The full maximum monthly allowance of all supplemental foods in all food packages should be made available to participants unless medically or nutritionally warranted.
- C. Tailoring the package to provide less than the full amount is appropriate when, for example:
 - 1. It is medically or nutritionally warranted such as removing an item due to a food allergy.
 - 2. When a participant refuses or cannot use the maximum monthly amount.
- D. Food packages for women and children 1-5 can be tailored to include sunflower seed butter as an additional option for the beans and peanut butter food item.

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1. If clients prefer sunflower seed butter based on dietary needs, client preference, cultural practices, etc., the issuing CA or WCS will inform the client that they can get sunflower seed butter with their “beans or peanut butter” benefit.
 2. No changes to the food package are required in the MIS.
 3. Medical documentation is not required.
- E. The parent/guardian of an infant 6-11 months of age may choose a fruit and vegetable cash value benefit (CVB) in place of all or some containers of infant fruits and/or vegetables after an individual nutrition assessment.
1. A CA or WCS must individually assess caregiver preference prior to issuing a food package with an infant CVB.
 2. When issuing a food package with an infant CVB, the CA or WCS must provide appropriate nutrition education on safe food preparation, storage techniques and feeding practices.
 - a. This can be accomplished by providing Preparing Fruits and Vegetables for Your Baby (stock no. 13-06-16828) or web-based resources.
 - b. Examples of documentation in the MIS may include but are not limited to a nutrition note during the midpoint or NE appointment, proof of appropriate NE or a record of sending a digital resource.
 3. The parent/guardian of an infant 6-11 months of age may select one of the following food package options:
 - a. Maximum amount (32 4-ounce containers) of infant fruits and/or vegetables (default issuance)
 - b. Maximum infant CVB
 - c. Half the amount (16 4-ounce containers) of infant fruits and/or vegetables and half the infant CVB

III. Food Package Exchanges

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- A. Food packages can be exchanged in the current month by modifying benefits if the remaining benefits meet the following criteria:
1. The quantities of each food are equal to or more than the quantity in the original food package, and
 2. The types of foods are the same as in the original food package, or if not the same, the food has not been redeemed.
 - a. Items within the milk substitution group described in I.B.2 are considered the same type of food and can be exchanged as available to that participant category.
 - i. Example 1: A pregnant participant wants to exchange her regular low-fat milk for low-fat lactose-free milk. Staff may exchange the regular low-fat milk for low-fat lactose-free milk, even if the regular low-fat milk was partially redeemed.
 - ii. Example 2: A 3-year-old child received low-fat milk, but then their caregiver obtains a prescription for a nutritional supplement, so the child is eligible to receive whole milk. Staff may exchange the low-fat milk for whole milk even if the low-fat milk was partially redeemed.
 - b. Infant 6-11 month food packages can be exchanged if less than half of the containers of infant fruits and/or vegetables have been redeemed. Staff may exchange 16 of the remaining containers for half of the infant CVB amount after an individual assessment as described in II. D.
 - c. A food package exchange may not be possible if foods from the first package were redeemed in an amount that exceeds the amount in the newly requested food package. For example - a Fully Breastfeeding Package with all 20 ounces of canned fish already redeemed cannot be exchanged for a Postpartum Package because that only contains 10 ounces of canned fish.
- B. Formula Food Package Exchanges

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1. Formula to Formula
 - a. Any formula food package can be exchanged for another formula food package at any time if the formula quantity in the economic unit's Electronic Benefit Account (EBA) and/or quantity returned is equal to or more than the formula quantity in the new food package.
 - b. When exchanging food packages with formula, formula will not be prorated for the current month.
 - c. When a Partially Breastfeeding food package has been issued with less than the partial maximum amount of formula and the mother returns to request additional formula within the current benefit period, follow the procedures below:
 - i. Staff may increase up to the partial maximum without a change in the Mother's food package.
 - ii. To increase to full formula package:
 - a) Provide breastfeeding counseling according to Policy BF:01.0 Breastfeeding Promotion and Support Standards, Procedure III.D.
 - b) Inform the woman that if she chooses to continue breastfeeding at least one time a day but prefers to receive a full package of formula for her infant, she will not be eligible to receive food benefits after the infant turns six months of age, but will be eligible to receive breastfeeding support.
 - c) If the woman still desires an increase in formula, staff must verify that the woman's current food package can be modified in the MIS.
2. Formula to Non-Formula - a formula food package can be exchanged for non-formula food package if the amount of formula originally issued either remains in the economic

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unit's EBA and/or the unopened formula containers are returned to clinic.

3. Non-formula to Formula – When a non-formula food package is exchanged for a formula food package, the quantity of food originally issued must be equal or more than the quantity of food in the new food package.
4. Fully Breastfeeding to Formula –
 - a. When a Fully Breastfeeding food package has been issued and the mother returns for formula before her infant turns six months, the food package can be exchanged in the current month if the remaining benefits quantities of each food are equal to or more than the quantity in the original food package, and
 - b. Staff may then perform a food package exchange and modify benefits for the mother's food package and issue a formula package to the infant for current and future months. See Policy [FD:10.0 Issuing Food Packages for the Mother/Infant Dyad](#) for more information.
 - c. If there are not enough remaining benefits for the current month:
 - i. A food package exchange cannot be performed.
 - ii. Refer the mother to the local agency peer counselor or lactation consultant and/or local resources for formula.